



your Pocket Music

Now you can carry your music wherever you go, with the help of portable MP3 players. We look at the latest offerings by various manufacturers to help you select the one for you

Connoisseurs of music are always in search of the perfect portable player. MP3 players have come close with their small form factor and the sheer amount of music you can carry. Though some of them are still expensive, they are a common sight. Here we compare the best of the lot to help you choose one that is best suited to your needs.

MP3 players come in three main categories, depending upon the storage medium used—solid-state, hard drive-based and CD MP3 players. While solid-state memory MP3 players are tiny and extremely portable, they can store a maximum of 256 MB of data. On the other hand, hard drive-based players, such as the Apple iPod offer up to 30 GB of storage space and more features, but they are bigger and much more expensive. CD MP3 players are cheap and use inexpensive media, but do not look as cool as the others. We looked at the solid-state MP3 players available today to help you make the right choice. Solid state MP3 players are tiny memory-based players. The absence of moving parts ensures that you get good quality music regardless of who's rocking the boat.

Apacer Audio Steno BP300

Battery guzzling fashion accessory

This funky and futuristic looking player from Apacer moonlights as a USB portable storage device, a MP3 and WMA player, and also a

voice recorder. It has a small rectangular backlit LCD, two volume control buttons and a Play or Pause button that also doubles as a power switch. The record, lock and menu jog switch are located on the underbelly. The LCD displays the track title from the ID3 tag, battery status, and indicates any other chosen settings. Removing the coloured cap at the top of the device reveals a USB connector that plugs directly into the USB port of your computer. The cap can be secured to the device with the cord provided, so that you don't lose it—even if you do, you can use one of the two different coloured spares that are thoughtfully provided, or just choose a colour to match your wardrobe! The player can be worn around your neck, using the provided strap—a good thing too, as it seems fragile.

Connecting the device to your PC is as easy as plugging it into the USB port, either directly or by using the USB extension cord that is provided. It is recognised as a removable drive, and you can use Windows Explorer to copy music or data to it—though the manufacturer strongly recommends using the bundled transfer software, which also includes a format utility. One goof-up here is that when you install the Audio Update application, a window pops up telling you to switch the MP3 device to 'Recovery mode'—there is no information on how to do this, neither in the user guide, nor on the manufacturers Web site.

The 128 MB storage is enough to store 24 MP3s encoded at 160 Kbps with an average size of 5 MB. You cannot create a